

AI Platform Engineering Build Challenge

The goal is to see **how you build with AI** - how you turn a small budget and a blank page into something real, useful, and safe. We care about your judgment and taste, not how many hours you burn.

BUILD-WEEK

WINDOW 1 WEEK

HANDS-ON **A FEW HOURS**
BUDGET **\$250 CLAUDE KEY**

001 The Challenge

OPEN BRIEF

THE BUILD

We give you a Claude API key capped at **\$250** and **one week**. Build something a company like Saronic - or any enterprise adopting AI - would actually want to use: an **agent, tool, automation, or service** with a real backend and live integrations, not a demo. What you build is entirely your call. Make it something you would be proud to show us.

THE KEY & BUDGET

Set the key we send you as **ANTHROPIC_API_KEY** and use it from your own machine - with the SDK, the **Anthropic CLI**, or **Claude Code**. Use it for **everything**; please do not spend your own tokens. The **\$250 cap is firm**, and how you spend it is part of what we look at / it burns faster than you think.

GROUND RULES

Any language, framework, or model you like / use AI tools freely, that is the job / **synthetic or public data only**, nothing confidential / plan on **a few hours** of hands-on work across the week, not a full week - do not torch your weekend / you keep all rights to what you build, we will not use it.

002 What to Submit

ONE GITHUB REPO

The Build

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The working thing itself, in a repo we can clone.

- **Runnable**, or clearly documented to run
- Real backend / integration, **not slideware**
- Full, honest **commit history** - we read it

Evals & Failure

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Show us it works, and how it behaves when things go wrong.

- A simple **evals / quality harness**
- **Graceful failure** on bad or hostile input
- Safe-by-default handling of secrets & data

The README

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Your writeup lives here - all of it, in the repo.

- What it is & **why an enterprise wants it**
- Architecture & how you made it reliable
- What you would build next

Decision & Cost Log

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In the README: the thinking behind the build.

- Key decisions & **what you rejected, why**
- Where the AI **led you astray** & how you caught it
- How you spent the **\$250** & what you would optimize

Everything lives in one GitHub repo - README, decision & cost log, evals, and build. The **only** thing you send us is an email with the link to the repo; nothing else goes in the email.

003 How We Evaluate

RUBRIC

Product Sense

25%

Solves a real problem an enterprise would want fixed; the make-it-easy, sanctioned-path mindset.

Reliability

25%

Real backend, not a demo. Evals, failure handling, and safe-by-default data judgment.

AI Fluency

20%

Agentic loops, tool use & MCP, context, model choice, and evals - used with intent.

Cost Sense

15%

How you spent the \$250: routing, caching, efficiency - and the quality of your reflection.

Comms

15%

A README that makes it clear and teachable. Could you explain this to a non-expert?

We read every submission end to end and may follow up with **a few written questions** about your decisions. Strong builds advance to the **on-site loop** - where you can present this very project.

004 Quick Tips for Success

APPROACH

01 Scope for signal, not size

A small, sharp, **working** thing beats an ambitious broken one. Pick something you can make genuinely good.

02 Spend like it is yours

\$250 burns fast on big models and long context. **Route models, cache prompts**, do not brute-force.

03 Show your judgment

The **why** matters. Capture what you tried, rejected, and where the model got it wrong.

04 Make it real

Runnable, with evals and graceful failure, beats a slick demo. Assume we **read the code** and the README.

HOW TO SUBMIT

Push everything to a **GitHub repo** - the build, the evals, the full commit history, and a **README** holding your writeup, decision log, and cost note. Then **email the repo link to cybersecurity@saronic.com** - the link is all we need, everything else stays in the repo. Blocked, or the key acting up? Email us anytime. Good luck - have fun with it.